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Changing the Face of Poverty

Nonprofits and the Problem of Representation

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Diana George examines the difficulties of adequately documenting poverty, especially for activist purposes. Through a case study of Habitat for Humanity publicity videos, George illustrates the inadequacy of such representations that depict poverty as a radically different from "average" American lives. This scholarly article from the anthology Popular Literacy: Studies in Cultural Practices and Poetics *also suggests possible ways to more accurately capture the complexity of poverty. Diana George works as the Director of Composition Studies at Virginia Tech.*

> *Constructively changing the ways the poor are represented in every aspect of life is one progressive intervention that can challenge everyone to look at the face of poverty and not turn away.*
>
> —Bell Hooks, *Outlaw Culture.*

ENCLOSED: No Address Labels to Use Up.
No Calendars to Look At.
No Petitions to Sign.

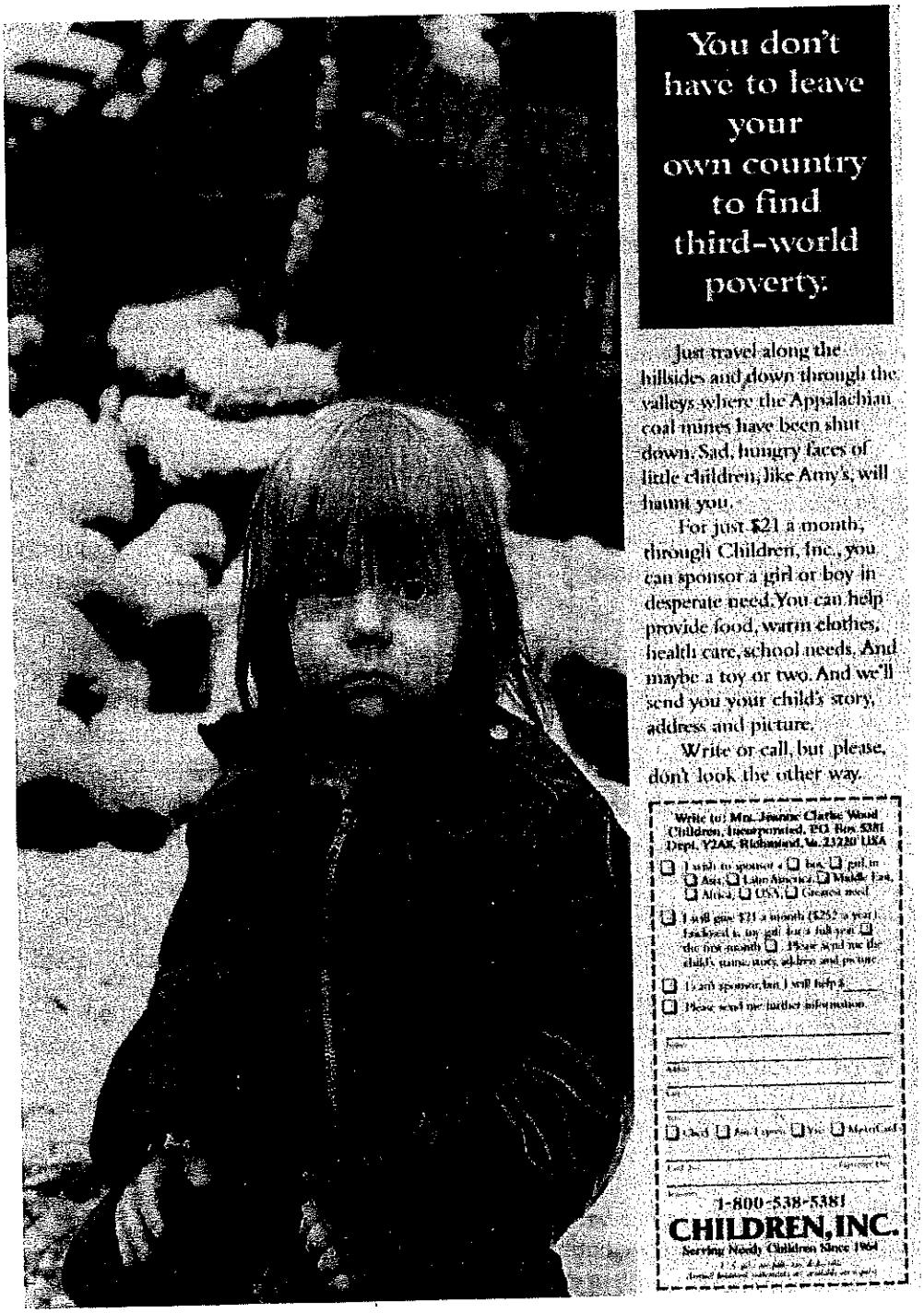
And No Pictures of Starving Children.

Figure 1. Text from the outer envelope of a 1998 Oxfam appeal

As I write this, Thanksgiving is near. I am about to go out and fill a box with nonperishables for the annual St. Vincent De Paul food drive. Christmas lights already outline some porches. Each day my mailbox is stuffed with catalogs and bills and with appeals from the Native American Scholarship Fund, the Salvation Army, WOJB—Voice of the Anishinaabe, the Navaho Health Foundation, the Barbara Kettle Gundlach Shelter Home for Abused Women, Little Brothers Friends of the Elderly, Habitat for Humanity, and more. One *New Yorker* ad for *Children, Inc.* reads, "You don't have to leave your own country to find third-world poverty." Alongside the ad copy, from a black-and-white full-page photo, a young girl in torn and ill-fitting clothes looks directly at the viewer. The copy continues. "Just travel along the hillsides and down through the valleys where the Appalachian coal mines have been shut down. Sad, hungry faces of little children, like Amy's, will haunt you."

The Oxfam promise that I quote above—to use no pictures of starving children—is surely an attempt to avoid the emotional overload of such images as the one *Children, Inc.* offers (Figure 2). Still, those pictures—those representations of poverty—have typically been one way nonprofits have kept the poor before us. In a culture saturated by the image, how else do we convince Americans that—despite the prosperity they see all around them—there is real need out there? The solution for most nonprofits has been to show the despair. To do that they must represent poverty as something that can be seen and easily recognized: fallen down shacks and trashed out public housing, broken windows, dilapidated porches, barefoot kids with stringy hair, emaciated old women and men staring out at the camera with empty eyes. In such images, poverty is dirt and rags and helplessness. In mail, in magazines, and in newspapers, ads echoing these appeals must vie for our time, attention, and dollars with Eddie Bauer, Nordstrom's, the Gap, and others like them whose polished and attractive images fill our days.

In the pages that follow, I offer one way of understanding how the images nonprofits must rely on may, as Stanley Aronowitz has noted about so many public appeals, result in charity but not activism—not in real structural change or an understanding of the systems that remain in place to keep many in poverty even while the culture at large is a prosperous one.[1] I begin with a discussion of what it means to rely on an image to represent an argument about something as complex as poverty and social responsibility—and how nonprofits must convince potential benefactors that they are dealing with the *most* needy, with the "deserving" and not the "undeserving" poor. In the second part of this essay. I examine a particular representation of poverty—publicity videos produced by Habitat for Humanity—in order



You don't have to leave your own country to find third-world poverty.

Just travel along the hillsides and down through the valleys where the Appalachian coal mines have been shut down. Sad, hungry faces of little children, like Amy's, will haunt you.

For just $21 a month, through Children, Inc., you can sponsor a girl or boy in desperate need. You can help provide food, warm clothes, health care, school needs. And maybe a toy or two. And we'll send you your child's story, address and picture.

Write or call, but please, don't look the other way.

Write to: Mrs. Jeanne Clarke Wood
Children, Incorporated, PO Box 5381
Dept. Y2AK, Richmond, Va. 23220 USA

☐ I wish to sponsor a ☐ boy ☐ girl in ☐ Asia, ☐ Latin America, ☐ Middle East, ☐ Africa, ☐ USA, ☐ Greatest need

☐ I will give $21 a month ($252 a year) for a boy or a girl for a full year ☐ the first month ☐. Please send me the child's name, story, address and picture.

☐ I can't sponsor, but I will help $_____

☐ Please send me further information.

Name _____
Address _____
City _____
State _____
☐ Check ☐ Am. Express ☐ Visa ☐ MasterCard
Card # _____ Expiration Date _____
Signature _____

1-800-538-5381

CHILDREN, INC.

Serving Needy Children Since 1964

Figure 2

to suggest that reliance on stereotypes of poverty can, in fact, work against the aims of the organization producing them. Finally, I look at alternate representations of poverty, especially those offered by the poor themselves and by men and women who work among the poor in this country. If it is possible, as bell hooks suggests above, to constructively change the ways the poor are represented, then such a change must begin with those whose lives are defined by need.

"We Must See Them": The Problems of Representation

Consumer's Union Executive Director Rhoda H. Karpatkin explains her motive for commissioning Eugene Richards's 1985 photo documentary *Below the Line: Living Poor in America* with a workplace anecdote: "In the Consumers Union lunchroom one day, I asked several of my suburban coworkers if they see people who are hungry or homeless. Many do not. Yet we must *see* them before we can care about them. And we must care about them before we are moved to end the intolerable conditions that mark their lives."[2] That motive—to *show* the reality of hard lives in order to move others to act or, at least, react—is an old one.

We might reach back to the paintings of eighteenth-century French moralist Jean-Baptist Grueze, who equated much poverty with moral decay, or to similar representations by Greuze's English contemporary William Hogarth, whose paintings and engravings of English street life linked abject poverty to an unholy and unrepentant lifestyle, one that might lead to the horrors of *Gin Lane,* or the dismal life and ultimate execution of the Idle Apprentice. Or, better yet, we could look to Sir William Beechey's 1793 portrait of the Ford children giving alms to a ragged boy they have encountered in the lane on the edge of their estate.[3] Painted in the manner of Gainsborough, these pretty, delicate upper-class children lean forward to place a coin in the hand of a young beggar—his rags barely covering him, his chest curved inward against hunger and cold.

Paintings, however, are easily understood as interpretations, even fictions—in the case of Grueze and Hogarth, they are eighteenth-century morality tales intended to uplift the monied class at the same time that they reconfirm old prejudices and fears. As industrialization concentrated more poverty and crime in the cities, nineteenth-century journalists and reformers turned to other ways of uncovering the truth and despair of urban poverty, once again, in order to move others to action or at least to sympathy.

Whatever his methods—and they are contested—moving readers to sympathy, if not reform, was certainly a motive for Henry Mayhew when in 1850–1851 he published the first of four volumes of interviews, stories, and firsthand descriptions detailing the lives of London's poor and working poor.[4] In his introduction to the final volume *Those That Will Not Work,* Mayhew writes of beginning with the aim of not simply contributing new facts or with only the hope of making "the solution of the social problem more easy to us, but, setting more plainly before us some of its latent causes, [to] make us look with more pity and less anger on those who want the fortitude to resist their influence."[5] Mayhew reveals with this short statement, and even with the title of this volume, the ambivalence with which even reformers or journalists sympathetic to the plight of the poor approached their subject. "Those that will not work": are they victims to be pitied, or are they simply

a drain on resources, a site of criminal behavior, or worse? What Mayhew asks is that his readers, in the least, temper their anger.

At the turn of this century, American novelist and journalist Jack London traveled to England to look again at London street life, to do more than Mayhew and actually *become* one of the London homeless. His accounts, as well, provide almost too vivid moments of the actuality of living in destitution. At one point as London walks beside two men who keep picking things up from the side-walk, he is so taken aback when he understands what they are doing that he pauses in shock and, for his reader, puts his revelation into italics: "*They picked up stray crumbs of bread the size of peas, apple cores so black and dirty one would not take them to be apple cores, and these things these two men took into their mouths, and chewed them, and swallowed them; and this, between six and seven o-clock in the evening of August 20, year of our Lord 1902, in the heart of the greatest, wealthiest, and most powerful empire the world has ever seen.*"[6] For London, in contrast to Mayhew, there was little question of who or what was to blame. Writing in a moment of social realism with such contemporaries as Theodore Dreiser and Frank Norris, whose short stories and novels placed the individual at the mercy of an American capitalist machine out of control, London collects the stories of England's street people, thrown out to hunger and cold when industry has no more use for them: "The unfit and the unneeded! Industry does not clamor for them. There are no jobs going begging through lack of men and women. . . . Women and plenty to spare, are found to toil under the sweat-shop masters for tenpence a day of fourteen hours. Alfred Freeman crawls to muddy death because he loses his job. Ellen Hughes Hun prefers Regent's Canal to Islington Workhouse. Frank Cavilla cuts the throats of his wife and children because he cannot find work enough to give them food and shelter."[7] It is a bleak world made all the more bleak by the assuredness with which London offers his readers little hope.

For reformers, the firsthand account has perennially been the most compelling, for it is through such stark representations that writers and, even more so, photographers challenge their audiences to dare deny the truth before them. Photojournalist Jacob A. Riis's 1890 publication *How the Other Half Lives,* the first thoroughgoing attempt at documenting poverty using photography, certainly marked a turning point for social reform. Using his camera as a way to capture New York tenement life, Riis showed the filth, decay, chaos, and dangerous crowding of which most Americans knew nothing. For Riis, the tenements were "the nurseries of pauperism and crime that fill our jails and police courts; that throw off a scum of forty thousand human wrecks to the island asylums and workhouses year by year; that turned out in the last eight years a round half million beggars to prey upon our charities; that maintain a standing army of ten thousand tramps with all that that implies; because, above all, they touch the family life with deadly moral contagion." Quite bluntly, Riis challenged his readers: "What are you going to do about it?"[8] Riis's photographs are such unflinching documents that they are often credited with forcing housing reform in New York's tenement district.

It was that bluntness, the promise of photography to show what we might not otherwise see, that gave the publisher of Helen Campbell's *Darkness and Daylight: or Lights and Shadows of New York Life* the courage to boast that here we have a volume of uncommon faithfulness to the harsh face of street life in 1892 New

York, brought even more vividly into view by "recent developments in photography [which] have rendered it possible to catch instantaneously all the details of a scene with the utmost fidelity." "It is said," writes this publisher, "that figures do not lie. Neither does the camera. In looking on these pages, the reader is brought face to face with real life as it is in New York; *not* AS IT WAS, but AS IT IS TODAY. Exactly as the reader sees these pictures, just so were the scenes presented to the camera's merciless and unfailing eye at the moment when the action depicted took place. Nothing is lacking but the actual *movement* of the persons represented."[9] Despite the publisher's assurance that we have before us what was captured by the untainted lens of the camera, the illustrations for *Darkness and Daylight are,* in fact, engravings made from the photos of Bellevue Hospital photographer O. G. Mason, photojournalist Riis, and others. Still, the claim is crucial to the book's argument that we must be able to *see* the poverty (and depravity) that fills the streets of New York in order to truly understand it and, ultimately, to be moved to end it. The motive is a humanistic one—the belief that seeing is not only believing but understanding as well. Furthermore, such a belief constitutes a faith that, once understood, the problem can—indeed will—be solved.

In depicting the poor, whether in literature, journalism, painting, or photography, representations swing between imaging the impoverished as dangerous, intemperate, low-life street thugs, or as helpless victims. Often, the two representations are somehow set together, as in Mayhew's depiction of those who *will not* work but whose lives must still be looked on with pity. Helen Campbell's volume—while it has much in common with *Riis's How the Other Half Lives* and even takes some of its engravings from those and similar photographs—actually is the story of a Christian temperance mission, suggesting that the true horror of New York Street life begins and ends in the bottle. The pages of this dense book are headed with such running titles as "Human Beasts in Filthy Dens."[10] Of the reformers I mention above, it is only London who rarely strays from the insistence that the impoverished he sees are victims of a larger system. His refrain, "Then the thing happens," is London's way of reminding his readers that the homeless wanderers he spends his days with are only an unfortunate incident away from having been self-supporting working-class or middle-class men and women.

For Hogarth and Grueze, the connection was clear: an immoral life led inevitably to a degraded condition. A return to morality was a return to prosperity and the warmth of hearth and home. Such stories of Penitent Magdalenes and Prodigal Sons might well seem appropriate moralistic tales for eighteenth-century class-conscious English society, and not at all related to what we understand of poverty in the United States today. And yet, the Appalachian child posing for *Children, Inc.* and the unwashed, unshaven, homeless man cautiously leaning into his coffee in a Milwaukee Rescue Mission photo[11] are likely to evoke much the same response as those eighteenth-century images: pity and alms-giving mixed with slight disapproval (Figure 3).

The issue at hand and the difficulty for nonprofits, then, is how to make real the dimensions of poverty and evoke the desire to give or to act without turning benefactors away. The question of seeing remains at the heart of problems of representation. What exactly is it that we see? Here I find Henry Mayhew's words once again useful for understanding what it is we might see. As he introduces

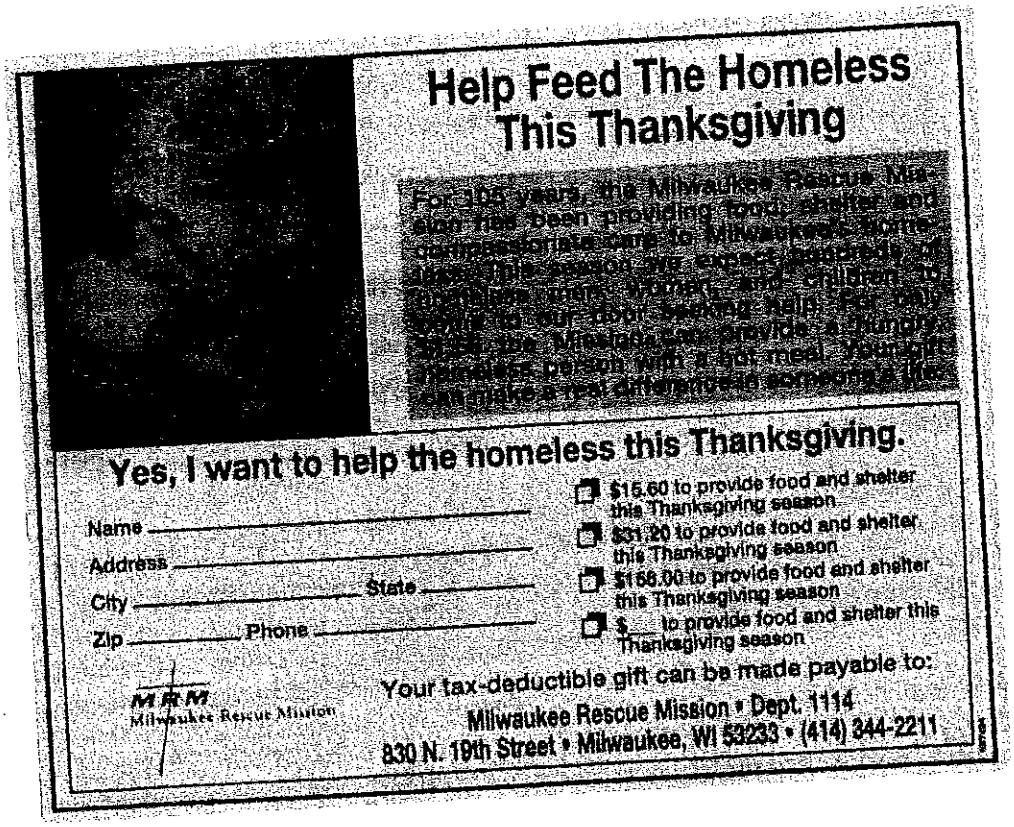


Figure 3

that final volume devoted to "those that will not work," Mayhew tells his readers,

> *The attainment of the truth, then, will be my primary aim; but by the truth, I wish it to be understood, I mean something more than the bare facts. Facts, according to my ideas, are merely the elements of truths, and not the truths themselves; of all matters there are none so utterly useless by themselves as your mere matters of fact. A fact, so long as it remains an isolated fact, is a dull, dead, uninformed thing; no object nor event by itself can possibly give us any knowledge, we must compare it with some other, even to distinguish it; and it is the distinctive quality thus developed that constitutes the essence of a thing.*[12]

If we think, then, of representation in the way cultural theorist Stuart Hall has explained it—as constitutive of reality or meaning rather than as an attempt to replicate a "fact" already there—easy to see and understand—then Mayhew's remarks must lead us to ask what it is we are representing in the images of poverty most in use by today's nonprofits. What, then, is the essence of this thing poverty as it takes form in the popular imagination?

Certainly this century's most extensive and thoroughgoing attempt to represent poverty in the United States has been the Farm Security Administration's vast photo project documenting the face of rural poverty throughout the Depression and Dust

Bowl years. Following the tradition of earlier documentarists like Riis and Lewis Hine, photographers including Walker Evans, Dorothea Lange, Arthur Rothstein, and others of the FSA created some of the most recognized images we have of America in hardship. These images continue, I would argue, to set the limits for representations of poverty today. Yet, even those images, as historian James Curtis notes in his full-length study of FSA photography, are not mere "facts" recorded with the unflinching eye of the camera lens. The clientele for these images—like the clientele for today's nonprofits—was primarily urban and middle class, and these images, "and entire photographic series," Curtis writes, were manipulated "to conform to the dominant cultural values" of this clientele.[13]

In his analysis of Dorothea Lange's photograph of Florence Thompson, generally known as *Migrant Mother or Migrant Madonna,* Curtis points particularly to the photographic choices Lange made that were "undoubtedly influenced by prevailing cultural biases."[14] The FSA documentary project portrayed the human spirit, the indomitable will of individuals who refused to yield to troubles they could not control, and *Migrant Mother* was certainly that. Florence Thompson, Curtis tells us, was traveling with her husband and seven children in the migrant work camps of California when Lange encountered her, and the choices Lange made in coming to that final shot that is now so recognizable were crucial for the way the image has been read over the years. The series of shots Lange took leading up to the final image indicates, for example, that she made the decision to leave a teenage daughter out, to compose the final group in a classic Madonna and child manner, to eliminate the clutter of the makeshift shelter and more—decisions that, in essence, placed Florence Thompson and her children clearly into the class of *deserving* over undeserving, or shiftless, or any other less acceptable representation that might have been made from the same family. This is an image that America not only accepted but embraced as emblematic of human courage and strength. In fact, this image remains so familiar that in 1998 the United States Postal Service chose it as one of several that would represent the thirties in a run of stamps commemorating each decade of the twentieth century.

In any number of nonprofit appeals, we can see versions of *Migrant Mother,* or of the shacks and bare dirt yards and delicate children in tattered clothing so familiar in Walker Evans's FSA photos. The issue is not that such conditions did not exist then. They did. They do today as well. And yet to rely primarily on these kinds of images while the country, the economy, the conditions, and the dimensions of poverty and need have changed considerably is to limit the ways nonprofits might respond to the need that is there.

Habitat for Humanity: A Case in Point

I have chosen Habitat for Humanity publicity videos for my focus because Habitat is a popular and far-reaching nonprofit with affiliates not only in the United States but throughout the world. Its goal is not a modest one: Habitat for Humanity aims to eliminate poverty housing from the globe. More than that, Habitat puts housing into the hands of the people who will be housed—into the hands of the homeowners and their neighbors. This is not another program aimed at keeping people in what has become known as the poverty or welfare cycle.

To be very clear, then, I am not criticizing the work of Habitat for Humanity. It is an organization that has done an amazing job of addressing what is, as cofounder Millard Fuller tells us again and again, a worldwide problem. What I would draw attention to, however, is how that problem of inadequate housing and its solution are represented, especially in publicity material produced and distributed by the organization, and how those representations can feed into the troubles that Habitat continues to have as it attempts to change the ways Americans think of helping others. What's more, the kinds of visual arguments Habitat and other nonprofits use to advocate for action or change have become increasingly common tools for getting the message to the public, and yet, I would argue, these messages too often fail to overturn cultural commonplaces that represent poverty as an individual problem that can be addressed on an individual basis. Habitat's catch phrase—A Hand Up, Not a Hand-Out—appeals to a nation that believes anyone can achieve economic security with just the right attitude and set of circumstances.

Habitat's basic program has a kind of elegance. Applicants who are chosen as homeowners put in sweat equity hours to build their home and to help build the homes of others chosen by Habitat. The organization then sells the home to the applicant at cost (that cost held down through Habitat's ability to provide volunteer labor and donated materials) and charges a small monthly mortgage that includes no interest. Unlike public assistance, which is raised or lowered depending on the recipient's circumstances, most Habitat affiliates do not raise mortgage payments when homeowners get better jobs or find themselves in better financial shape. And once the house is paid for, it belongs to the home-owner.

Obviously, in order to run a program like this one, Habitat must produce publicity appeals aimed at convincing potential donors to give time, money, and material. Print ads, public service television and radio spots, commercial appeals linked to products like Maxwell House coffee, and publicity videos meant to be played for churches, volunteer organizations, and even in-flight video appeals on certain airlines are common media for Habitat.

Habitat publicity videos are typically configured as problem-solution arguments. The problem is that too many people have inadequate shelter. The solution is community involvement in a program like Habitat for Humanity. The most common setup for these productions is an opening sequence of images—a visual montage—in which we see black-and-white shots of rural shacks, of men and women clearly in despair, and of thin children in ragged clothing. The voice-over narrative of one such montage tells us the story:

> *Poverty condemns millions of people throughout the world to live in deplorable and inhuman conditions. These people are trapped in a cycle of poverty, living in places offering little protection from the rain, wind, and cold. Terrible sanitary conditions make each day a battle with disease and death. And, for this, they often pay over half their income in rent because, for the poor, there are no other choices. Daily, these families are denied a most basic human need: a decent place to live. The reasons for this worldwide tragedy are many. They vary from city to city, country to country, but the result is painfully the same whether the families are in New York or New Delhi.*[15]

It is a compelling dilemma.

Organizations like Habitat for Humanity, in order to convey the seriousness of this struggle and, of course, to raise funds and volunteer support for their efforts in addressing it, must produce all sorts of publicity. And in that publicity they must tell us quickly what the problem is and what we can do to help. To do that, Habitat gives us a visual representation of poverty, a representation that mirrors the most common understandings of poverty in America.

Now, there is nothing inherently wrong with that representation unless, of course, what you want to do (as Habitat does) is convince the American people to believe in the radical idea that those who have must care for the needs of others, not just by writing a check, but by enabling an entirely different life-style. For Americans, it is truly radical to think that our poorer neighbors might actually be allowed to buy a home at no interest and with the donated time and materials of others. It is a radical notion that such a program means that these neighbors then own that house and aren't obliged to do more than keep up with payments in order to continue owning it. And it is a radical idea that Habitat does this work not only in our neighborhoods (not isolated in low-income housing developments) but throughout the world. Habitat International truly believes that we are all responsible for partnering with our neighbors throughout the world so that everyone might eventually have, at least, a simple decent place to live. Like the philosophy behind many nonprofits, Habitat's is not a mainstream notion.

Still, that representation of poverty—clinging as it does to commonplaces drawn from FSA photographs in this century, from Jacob Riis's nineteenth-century photos of urban poverty, and from documentaries of Third World hunger—has serious limitations, which must be obvious to those who remember the moment that the Bush administration confidently announced that, after looking everywhere, they had discovered no real hunger in the United States. And that myth that poverty cannot/does not actually exist in the heart of capitalism has once again been reinforced in the 1998 Heritage Foundation report in which Robert Rector echoed the perennial argument that there is little true poverty in this country ("Myth").[16] Heritage Foundation's finding comes despite figures from the National Coalition for the Homeless ("Myths and Facts About Homelessness"), which tell us that in 1997 nearly one in five homeless people in twenty-nine cities across the United States was employed in a full- or part-time job.[17]

In her call for a changed representation of poverty in America, bell hooks argues that in this culture poverty "is seen as synonymous with depravity, lack and worthlessness." She continues, "I talked with young black women receiving state aid, who have not worked in years, about the issue of representation. They all agree that they do not want to be identified as poor. In their apartments they have the material possessions that indicate success (a VCR, a color television), even if it means that they do without necessities and plunge into debt to buy these items."[18] Hers is hardly a noble image of poverty, but it is a true one and one that complicates the job of an organization like Habitat that must identify "worthy" applicants. This phenomenon of poverty in the center of wealth, in a country with its national mythology of hearty individuals facing the hardness of the Depression with dignity and pride, is certainly a part of what Manning Marable challenges when he asks readers not to judge poverty in the United States by the standards of

other countries. Writing of poverty among black Americans, Marable reminds us that "the process of impoverishment is profoundly national and regional."[19] It does little good to compare the impoverished of this country with Third World poverty or, for that matter, with Depression Era poverty.

The solution in these Habitat videos is just as visible and compelling a representation as is the problem. The solution, it seems, is a modern-day barn raising. In clip after clip, Habitat volunteers are shown lined up to raise walls, to hammer nails, to cut boards, to offer each other the "hand up not a hand out," as these publicity messages tell us again and again. Like the barn- raising scene from Peter Weir's *Witness,* framed walls come together against blue skies. People who would normally live in very different worlds come together to help a neighbor. It is all finished in record time: a week, even a day. Volunteers can come together quickly. Do something. Get out just as quickly.

The real trouble with Habitat's representation, then, is twofold: it tells us that the signs of poverty are visible and easily recognized. And it suggests that one of the most serious results of poverty (inadequate shelter) can be addressed quickly with volunteer efforts to bring individuals up and out of the poverty cycle.

Of course, if Habitat works, what could be wrong with the representation? It is an organization so popular that it receives support from diametrically opposed camps. Newt Gingrich and Jesse Jackson have both pounded nails and raised funds for Habitat. This is what Millard Fuller calls the "theology of the hammer." People might not agree on political parties and they might not agree on how to worship or even what to worship, Fuller says, but they can all agree on a hammer. All can come together to build houses. Or, can they?

As successful as Habitat has been, it is an organization that continues to struggle with such issues as who to choose for housing, how to support potential homeowners, and how to convince affiliates in the United States to tithe a portion of their funds to the real effort of Habitat: eliminating poverty housing throughout the world, not just in the United States. And, even in the United States, affiliates often have trouble identifying "deserving" applicants or convincing local residents to allow Habitat homes to be built in their neighborhoods. There are certainly many cultural and political reasons for these problems, but I would suggest that the way poverty continues to be represented in this country and on tapes like those videos limits our understanding of what poverty is and how we might address it.

That limitation holds true for those caught in poverty as well as those wanting to help. What if, as a potential Habitat applicant, you don't recognize yourself or you refuse to recognize yourself in those representations? As Stanley Aronowitz points out in *The Politics of Identity,* that can happen very easily as class identities, in particular, have become much more difficult to pin down since World War II, especially with an expansion of consumer credit that allowed class and social status to be linked to consumption rather than to professions or even wages. In his discussion of how electronic media construct the *social imaginary,* Aronowitz talks of the working class with few media representations available to them as having fallen into a kind of "cultural homelessness."[20] How much more true is that of the impoverished in this country who may be neither homeless nor ragged, but are certainly struggling every day to feed their families, pay rent, and find jobs that pay more than what it costs for daycare?

I have been particularly interested in this last question because of a difficulty I mentioned earlier, that of identifying appropriate applicants for Habitat homes or even getting some of the most needy families of a given affiliate to apply for Habitat homes. When I showed the video *Building New Lives* to Kim Puuri, a Copper Country Habitat for Humanity homeowner and now member of the affiliate's Homeowner Selection Committee, and asked her to respond, she was very clear in what she saw as the problem:

> *When I see those pictures I usually think of Africa or a third world country and* NOT *the U.S. It's not that they can't be found here, it's just that you don't publicly see people that bad off other than street people. If they could gear the publicity more to the geographical areas, it may make more of an impact or get a better response from people. It would mean making several videos. It may not be so much of a stereotype, but an association between Habitat and the people they help. People viewing the videos and pictures see the conditions of the people and feel that their own condition may not be that bad and feel they probably wouldn't qualify.*[21]

What this Habitat homeowner has noticed is very close to what Hall describes. That is, the problem with this image, this representation, is not that it is not real enough. The problem has nothing to do with whether or not these are images of poverty as it exists in the world. There is no doubt that this level of poverty does exist in this country and elsewhere despite the Heritage Foundation's attempts to demonstrate otherwise. The problem is that this representation of poverty is a narrow one and functions to narrow the ways we might respond to the poor who do not fit this representation.

The representation I have been discussing is one that insists on constructing poverty as an individual problem that can be dealt with by volunteers on an individual basis. That is the sort of representation common in this country, the sort of representation Paul Wellstone objects to in a recent call to action when he says "We can offer no single description of American poverty." What it takes to break through such a representation is first, as Stuart Hall suggests, to understand it as a representation, to understand it as a way of imparting meaning. And the only way to contest that representation, to allow for other meanings, other descriptions, is to know more about the many dimensions of poverty in America. "More than 35 million Americans—one out of every seven of our fellow citizens—are officially poor. More than one in five American children are poor. And the poor are getting poorer," Wellstone writes.[22] But we can be certain that much of that poverty is not the sort pictured in those black-and-white images. And if it doesn't *look* like poverty, then how do we address it? How do we identify those "deserving" our help?

Indeed, as Herbert Gans has suggested, the labels we have chosen to place on the poor in this country often reveal more than anything "an ideology of undeservingness," by which we have often elided poverty and immorality or laziness or criminality. "By making scapegoats of the poor for fundamental problems they have not caused nor can change," Gans argues, "Americans can also postpone politically difficult and divisive solutions to the country's economic ills and the need to prepare the economy and polity for the challenges of the twenty-first

century."[23] These are tough issues to confront and certainly to argue in a twenty-minute video presentation aimed at raising funds and volunteer support, especially when every piece of publicity must make a complex argument visible.

On the Way to Changing the Face of Poverty

Reflecting on more than thirty years of working among the poor, Dorothy Day once wrote, "Poverty is a strange and elusive thing. . . . We need always to be thinking and writing about it, for if we are not among its victims its reality fades from us."[24] Of course, that impulse—to keep the poor before us—is precisely what has led to the many firsthand accounts and documentary photographs and sociological studies and publicity videos like those I have mentioned above. But Day, who devoted her entire life to working with the poor, continues on in a passage quoted here at length for its directness and clear-headed understanding of what it means now, and has meant in the past, to be truly in need:

> *So many good souls who visit us tell us how they were brought up in poverty, but how, through hard work and cooperation, their parents managed to educate all the children—even raise up priests and nuns for the Church. They content that healthful habits and a stable family situation enable people to escape from the poverty class, no matter how mean the slum they may once have been forced to live in. The argument runs, so why can't everybody do it? No, these people don't know about the poor. Their concept of poverty is of something as near and well ordered as a nun's cell.*
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> *Poverty has many faces. People can, for example, be poor in space alone. . . . Then there are those who live under outwardly decent economic circumstances but are forever on the fearful brink of financial disaster. . . . No matter how high wages go, a sudden illness and an accumulation of doctor and hospital bills, for example, may mean a sudden plunge into destitution.*[25]

What Day tells us here recalls Jack London's warning: "Then the thing happens." It is a reminder that the poor are not only always among us, but at any time might *be* us. At any time so many Americans living on the very edge of financial health might be plunged into destitution.

I suspect some readers wonder why I continue to emphasize the very ordinary nature of those who live in poverty and why I not only consider it so important that nonprofits work to break older stereotypes, but that recipients of those nonprofit appeals learn to read the images of poverty with the knowledge that they are stereotypes and do limit our understanding of need. More than one of the many colleagues and friends I have besieged with my talk of poverty and nonprofit appeals has asked an important question: If nonprofits don't use images that show hunger and need, then how are they to get across the urgency of their message? How do they raise money or awareness? It is a question I have not always answered well or completely. I do believe, however, that an answer might lie in two areas: first, in a knowledge of the actual consequences of relying on those stereotypes to carry a message of need; and second, in an understanding of what we have sometimes called the "visual imperative" of the electronic media.

Once again, as long as people give to nonprofits to support poverty programs, what does the image matter? Does "the vocabulary of poverty," as Michael B. Katz claims, really impoverish the political imagination?[26] I offer one very quick example of how that vocabulary, that stereotype, does indeed impoverish the political imagination. Early in 1999, the Michigan legislature put on fast-track Governor John Engler's most recent plan to cut back the assistance rolls in his state. Engler proposed drug testing for all welfare recipients. Those tested positive would be sent to rehabilitation programs. If they fail to attend those programs or if they are found to continue drug use, they will be dropped from welfare rolls. Despite federal studies that indicate that only about 5 percent of welfare recipients are serious drug and alcohol abusers ("Welfare Drug Test"),[27] this legislation feeds into the notion that if someone is on assistance, there must be something wrong with that person, something that once fixed will make each individual a contributing, self-supporting member of the community.

Democrats' proposed amendments to the Engler bill weren't much better. Amendments asked that only those applicants who have not found a job after participating in Michigan's Work First program be screened "for potential drug and alcohol abuse, learning disabilities, illiteracy, domestic violence, actual or imminent homelessness and mental illness."[28] Clearly, the operative notion here is that only the most deviant, disabled, or disinclined to learn make up the ranks of those who cannot find work.

Although many would argue that such legislation is unconstitutional, it was no idle threat. By July 1999, the legislature has passed Engler's bill and drug testing had begun. Readers might well recall that John Engler's name came to national prominence during his first term in office when he began what has continued to be a deep slashing of public assistance and welfare rolls. His back-to-work or workfare programs have caught on throughout this country, and Engler has been heralded as a governor who takes people off welfare and puts them back into the workplace.

Barbara Ehrenreich's most recent experiment in which she became—Jack London-like—a low-wage employee, not to find out "how the other half lives" but to test out policies like Engler's that claim that "work will lift poor women out of poverty while simultaneously inflating their self-esteem and hence their future value in the labor market," vividly illustrates how impoverished this particular political imaginary actually is. Not only do most jobs held by low-wage employees offer no security and few or no benefits; they are simply not jobs that will provide a living wage. Ehrenreich explains, "According to the National Coalition for the Homeless, for example, in 1998 it took, on average nationwide, an hourly wage of $8.89 to afford a one-bedroom apartment, and the Preamble Center for Public Policy estimates that the odds against a typical welfare recipient's landing a job at such a 'living wage' are about 97 to 1."[29] These are not good odds, and they point again to the reality Dorothy Day wrote of so many years ago: it is important to help individuals, and individuals can certainly raise themselves up out of poverty, but helping the individual without addressing larger structural problems will do little more than help the individual.

The second concern I point to—understanding the role of the media in communicating need—may be even more crucial in changing the face of poverty, for it points directly to how the media work within certain "givens." Speaking on the difficulties of getting United States news media to carry the 1983 story of the

Ethiopian famine, communication scholar Brian Winston addresses one of those givens—what he calls the media myth of being in the "grip of the visual imperative."[30] Winston argues that, if we closely analyze the news media, we will discover that it is only such stories as Third World hunger that are caught in the grip of this visual imperative. Many other kinds of stories get long play with stock—even dull—footage. He names political election stories or stories of economics for which the media will find a number of images that we could not call compelling—the President getting off a plane, for example, or oil wells in a Kansas field. According to Winston, if we were instead to tell the story of hunger as a real story of problems of wealth and distribution and the like, then there would be all kinds of images that would work: wheat fields, graphs, ships moving grain, and more. Instead, however, the story of hunger and poverty exists on the level of crisis reportage so that, according to Winston, this kind of story is *located* in the image.

"Famine," Winston argues, "is a biblical word. We don't have famines in the West. Famines can only come into our collective consciousness . . . if it's in biblical terms." As if to reinforce Winston's point, Michael Buerke, whose BBC report did finally break the Ethiopian famine story in 1984, says much the same: "The curious thing—it came out in the first film we did—is that biblical business. People looked like those depicted in the color illustrations in my old school Bible. Sort of sackcloth color and a certain nobility of features."[31] Winston is much harsher in his assessment. He calls many of these images "masturbatory" images of hunger—a pornography of starvation.

If not those images, then what? Well, I would return to Habitat home-owner Kim Puuri's suggestion that Habitat might have to start making different videos or publicity pieces for different areas/different audiences. In that suggestion, Puuri is actually calling our attention to the most serious problem of such broad representations: they depict poverty as a crisis that we can recognize and address now with just a call, a contribution, a few hours of our time. In addition, these images depict poverty as something that happens to others, people outside the ordinary. As the Michigan legislation suggests, these people are addicts, illiterates and, worse yet, potentially *violent* addicts and illiterates.

Since I have focused many of my comments on Habitat for Humanity publicity, I feel compelled to turn first to Habitat for alternate representations of the people who apply for and get Habitat homes. My own local affiliate published the following fund-raising Christmas card for the 1997 Christmas season (Figure 4). The images of these families are remarkable only for the fact that they are our neighbors. This area, known as the Copper Country, is small enough that families receiving this appeal would recognize some or all of the families pictured on the card. They would have worked with them; many would even be related to them. They are people we know whose financial circumstances are not unlike that of many of their neighbors. What Copper Country Habitat is doing with a card like this one is, in some ways, risky. It is, after all, much easier to imagine need that is far away and desperate in ways that can be seen. Instead this affiliate is counting on the community to know that need looks a lot like the every day. It looks a lot like the people they live with and work with. In fact, it is the people they live and work with.

Other local affiliates do much the same. I have been especially impressed by the work of Chicago's Uptown affiliate. Uptown renovates old apartment houses and

We send thanks—
and thoughts & prayers
for a fine Holiday
and a Good Year—
to your family
from all of ours...

Figure 4

turns them into condos. In forming its homeowner's association, Uptown Habitat homeowners have written their own newsletters, written rules for the condo group, advocated for police attention to the crime outside their doorways, and more. The newsletter *HabiChat* published by Uptown Habitat looks much like many of the newsletters of neighborhood associations throughout suburban America. It includes announcements for Spring Clean-up, marriage and birth announcements, resources for parenting troubles, and more. Such newsletters, sent out as they are to the entire affiliate and not kept isolated within the homeowners association, work to remind Habitat volunteers and donors that Habitat's best work is fundamental to the lives of ordinary people working at one or more low-wage jobs and just trying to get by in safe, inexpensive, decent housing.

Of course, that is Habitat. Despite its goal to eliminate poverty housing on the globe, Habitat can rarely address the needs of the most impoverished. After all, a Habitat homeowner must come up with even a little money for a mortgage, and there are millions of Americans who cannot do that. What of those others? What about that man in the Milwaukee Rescue Mission ad I mentioned earlier? This is clearly a man with little enough to eat much less the resources for a house payment or even the energy for "sweat equity." Perhaps he is a part of those "undeserving" poor, the drunks and addicts Engler would like to push off Michigan's assistance rolls.

Again, I would call attention to how the homeless depict themselves. I offer one last, true story: Outside the San Francisco Hilton just after Christmas a year ago, I bought my third copy of *Streetwise: A Publication of the Coalition on Homelessness San Francisco*. It is not unlike papers sold by homeless men and women in several cities throughout this country. As I tucked the paper into my books, a short, well-dressed woman waiting for a cab turned to ask me if someone was handing out free things. "No. It's a paper. It costs a dollar." In anger, she came closer to me and yelled, "You *paid money* for that trash?"

Stunned both by the suddenness and the volume of her anger, I neglected to ask if she'd read the article on prisons and shelters signed by "Art B, One Homeless Guy, one of the 14,000 in San Francisco living in a shelter or under the freeways." It was pretty good, I wanted to tell her, but she was already off in her cab.

In these street papers, written as this one is by "the homeless and formerly homeless," we are presented with yet another image of desperate poverty. Perhaps because the homeless themselves write articles seeking to uncover the very structures that keep homelessness and poverty alive and well in our cities, some potential readers are driven to the kind of anger I witnessed. More likely, it is that the very sight of a homeless person, so very obviously in need of food, shelter, a recovery program, or more, is enough to frighten away the lady in the cab.

In Tucson during the past year, the City Council threatened to clear the medians of homeless people selling papers. The Council claimed these men and women represented a safety threat. In response Casa Maria, Tucson's Catholic Worker House, distributed a flyer calling for action to block the Council order. In it, Casa Maria accused the Council of acting on the basis of "aesthetics" rather than from any real concern over safety and pointed to the fact that many of the people who sell those papers have actually been able to pay rent and provide themselves with basic necessities just by being allowed to stand on those medians and sell newspapers.

Brian Flagg, a worker from Casa Maria, wrote recently "We won this one! It was cool—We filled their meeting with church people & uppity tramps!"[32]

It might indeed take uppity tramps, local newsletters, and committed activists like Brian to change constructively the ways the poor are represented, as bell hooks asks that we do. As well, however, it will take a clear understanding of need in its many forms, and for this the image of Amy standing in a deserted mining town and looking out from a black-and-white photo does not altogether tell *New Yorker* readers what they need to know.

Endnotes

1. Stanley Aronowitz, interview in the video production *Consumer Hunger: Part III Selling the Feeling* (Maryknoll, N.Y.: Maryknoll World Productions, 1988).
2. Eugene Richards, *Below the Line: Living Poor in America* (Mount Vernon, N.Y.: Consumers Union, 1987), 215.
3. Richard Leppert, *Art and the Committed Eye: The Cultural Functions of Imagery* (Boulder, Co.: Westview Press, 1996), 173–76.
4. Henry Mayhew, *London Labour and the London Poor* (New York: Penguin Books, 1985).
5. Ibid., 447.
6. Jack London, *The People of the Abyss*, facs. edn. (New York: Garrett P, MSS Information Corp., 1970), 78.
7. Ibid., 287–88.
8. Jacob A. Riis, *How the Other Half Lives: Studies among the Tenements of New York* (New York: Dover, 1971), 2.
9. Helen Campbell, *Darkness and Daylight; or Lights and Shadows of New York Life: A Woman's Story of Gospel, Temperance, Mission, and Rescue Work "In His Name"* (Hartford, Conn.: A. D. Worthington, 1892), viii–ix, x–xi (emphasis in the original).
10. Ibid., 99.
11. "Help Feed the Homeless This Thanksgiving," *Milwaukee Rescue Mission* ad appeal, *Milwaukee Journal Sentinel* (Saturday, 14 Nov. 1998), 8A. To be fair to the Milwaukee Rescue Mission, this photograph has been replaced in more recent ads by photos of mothers with children and other single homeless men. In a telephone interview, Pastor Patrick Vanderburgh, Executive Director of Milwaukee Rescue Mission, indicated that the mission has wrestled with the problem of how best to represent the need that is out there. Since this is a fundraising ad, the representation must move the public to charity, but according to Pastor Vanderburgh, even photos of mothers with children have not been nearly as successful in raising funds as this photo of a homeless man who very obviously fits the public's common idea of a street person.

12. Mayhew, *London Labour,* 448.
13. James Curtis, *Mind's Eye: Mind's Truth: FSA Photography Reconsidered* (Philadelphia: Temple University Press, 1989), viii–ix.
14. Ibid., 52.
15. *Building New Lives* (Americus, Ga.: Habitat for Humanity International). This and other Habitat videos are directed primarily at potential volunteers for the organization or might be used to inform local residents about the work of Habitat.
16. Robert Rector, "The Myth of Widespread American Poverty," *The Heritage Foundation Backgrounder* (18 Sept. 1998), no. 1221. This publication is available on-line at <http://www.heritage.org/library/backgrounder/bg1221es.html>.
17. Cited in Barbara Ehrenreich, "Nickel and Dimed: On (Not) Getting by in America," *Harper's* (January 1999), 44. See also Christina Coburn Herman's *Poverty Amid Plenty: The Unfinished Business of Welfare Reform* NETWORK, A National Social Justice Lobby (Washington, D.C., 1999), from NETWORK's National Welfare Reform Watch Project, which reports that most studies of welfare use telephone surveys even though a substantial percentage of those needing aid do not have phone service (41 percent in the NETWORK survey had no operative phone) and, therefore, are not represented in most welfare reform reports. This report is available on-line at <http://www.network-lobby.org>.
18. bell hooks, "Seeing and Making Culture: Representing the Poor," *Outlaw Culture: Resisting Representations* (New York: 1994), 169.
19. Manning Marable, *How Capitalism Underdeveloped Black America* (Boston: South End Press, 1983), 54.
20. Stanley Aronowitz, *The Politics of Identity: Class, Culture, Social Movements* (New York: Routledge, 1992), 201.
21. Kim Puuri, personal correspondence with author.
22. Paul Wellstone, "If Poverty Is the Question," *Nation* (14 April 1997), 15.
23. Herbert J. Gans, *The War Against the Poor* (New York: Basic Books, 1995), 6–7.
24. Dorothy Day, *Loaves and Fishes: The Inspiring Story of the Catholic Worker Movement* (Maryknoll, N.Y.: Orbis Books, 1997), 71.
25. Ibid., 71–72.
26. Michael B. Katz, *The Undeserving Poor: From the War on Poverty to the War on Welfare* (New York: Pantheon Books, 1989), 3.
27. "Welfare Drug Test Bill on Fast Track," *Detroit News* (4 Feb. 1999) <http://www.detnews.com>Metro/State edition.
28. Ibid.
29. Ehrenreich, "On (Not) Getting By," 38.

30. Interviewed in the video production *Consuming Hunger: Part I—Getting the Story* (Maryknoll, N.Y.: Maryknoll World Productions, 1988). These comments and the discussion that follows are drawn from the three-part video *Consuming Hunger* about media representations first of the famine crisis in Ethiopia and then of media representations of hunger in America culminating in the 1986 media event *Hands Across America*. At the time of this taping, Brian Winston was serving as Dean of Penn State's School of Communication.
31. *Consuming Hunger.*
32. Brian Flagg, personal correspondence with author.